

THE ULTIMATE KNITTING LIBRARY

Learn to Knit from Zero

Your Complete Beginner's Guide to Knitting

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SECTION 1

Choosing Your First Yarn & Needles

Build a starter kit that sets you up for success from your very first stitch.

The right materials make learning dramatically easier. A smooth, medium-weight yarn and a comfortable pair of needles will let you see your stitches clearly and build muscle memory without fighting your tools.

Yarn Weight for Beginners

Worsted weight (also labeled "medium" or "#4") is the best choice for your first project. It is thick enough to see clearly, widely available, affordable, and works with a comfortable needle size. Avoid very thin yarns (lace, fingering) and very bulky yarns until you have some practice.

Look for a smooth, light-colored yarn in acrylic or an acrylic-wool blend. Light colors let you see your stitches easily. Avoid dark, fuzzy, or textured yarns — they hide mistakes and make it harder to learn.

YARN WEIGHT	CATEGORY	TYPICAL NEEDLE SIZE	GOOD FOR BEGINNERS?
Lace (#0)	Super Fine	US 000–1 (1.5–2.25 mm)	No — too thin
Fingering (#1)	Super Fine	US 1–3 (2.25–3.25 mm)	No — too thin
Sport (#2)	Fine	US 3–5 (3.25–3.75 mm)	Not ideal
DK (#3)	Light	US 5–7 (3.75–4.5 mm)	OK
Worsted (#4)	Medium	US 7–9 (4.5–5.5 mm)	Best choice
Bulky (#5)	Bulky	US 9–11 (5.5–8 mm)	OK for scarves
Super Bulky (#6)	Super Bulky	US 11–17 (8–12 mm)	Fast but less control

Needle Materials

MATERIAL	PROS	CONS	BEST FOR
Bamboo	Lightweight, warm to the touch, slight grip keeps stitches from sliding off	Can splinter over time; slower knitting	Beginners (recommended)
Wood	Beautiful, warm, moderate grip	More expensive; can warp if wet	Beginners who want to invest

MATERIAL	PROS	CONS	BEST FOR
Metal (Aluminum)	Very smooth, durable, fast stitching	Stitches can slide off easily; cold to touch	Intermediate and advanced knitters
Plastic	Cheap, lightweight, large sizes available	Can feel flimsy; less precise	Budget-friendly start or very bulky yarn

Recommendation

Start with **bamboo needles in US size 8 (5 mm)**. The slight texture grips the yarn just enough to prevent dropped stitches, and the size is comfortable to hold for extended practice sessions.

Needle Sizes Explained

Knitting needles are sized in three systems: US, metric (mm), and UK. The US and metric sizes are most common. The metric measurement refers to the diameter of the needle shaft.

US SIZE	METRIC (MM)	UK SIZE	BEST YARN WEIGHT
US 6	4 mm	8	DK / Light Worsted
US 7	4.5 mm	7	Worsted
US 8	5 mm	6	Worsted (ideal starter)
US 9	5.5 mm	5	Worsted / Bulky
US 10	6 mm	4	Bulky

Your Starter Kit

Beginner Knitting Starter Kit

- ☐ 1 pair of bamboo straight needles, US 8 (5 mm), 10 inches / 25 cm long
- ☐ 2 skeins of worsted weight yarn (#4), smooth, light color (about 200 yards / 180 m each)
- ☐ 1 pair of small scissors
- ☐ 1 tapestry needle (blunt-tip, large eye) for weaving in ends
- ☐ 1 tape measure or ruler
- ☐ 4–6 stitch markers (split-ring or locking type)
- ☐ 1 row counter (optional but helpful)
- ☐ 1 small notebook to track your progress

Common Mistake

Buying fancy yarn for your first project. Your first few swatches will be uneven — that is completely normal. Use affordable acrylic yarn for practice and save the beautiful hand-dyed skeins for later when your tension is consistent.

SECTION 2

Casting On (4 Methods)

Learn four ways to put your first stitches on the needle — the foundation of every knitting project.

Casting on creates the first row of loops on your needle. Different cast-on methods produce different edges — some stretchy, some firm, some decorative. Master the long-tail first, then add the others to your toolkit.

Method 1: Long-Tail Cast On

The most popular and versatile cast on. It creates a neat, elastic edge and counts as your first row. Use it as your default for most projects.

- 1 Measure your tail.** Estimate about 1 inch (2.5 cm) of tail per stitch you need, plus 6 inches (15 cm) extra. For 20 stitches, pull out about 26 inches of yarn.
- 2 Make a slip knot.** Create a loop with the tail end crossing over the working yarn. Reach through the loop and pull the working yarn through to form a knot. Place it on one needle. This counts as your first stitch.
- 3 Position your hand.** Hold the needle in your right hand. Drape both strands over your left palm — the tail over your thumb, the working yarn over your index finger. Close your remaining fingers around both strands.
- 4 Scoop under the thumb strand.** Bring the needle tip under the yarn on the outside of your thumb, moving from the bottom up.
- 5 Grab the index finger strand.** Swing the needle over and behind the yarn on your index finger, catching it with the needle tip.
- 6 Pull through the thumb loop.** Bring the needle back down through the thumb loop. Release your thumb and gently tighten the new stitch on the needle.
- 7 Repeat** steps 4–6 until you have the required number of stitches. Keep your tension even — each stitch should slide along the needle but not fall off on its own.

Tension Tip

If your cast on is too tight, try casting onto two needles held together, then carefully pull one out. This gives you extra room and makes the first row much easier to knit into.

Method 2: Knitted Cast On

A simple method that uses the knit stitch itself. Good if you find the long-tail tricky at first, or when you need to add stitches in the middle of a row.

- 1 **Make a slip knot** and place it on the left needle.
- 2 **Insert the right needle** into the slip knot from left to right (knitwise).
- 3 **Wrap the yarn** around the right needle tip counterclockwise.
- 4 **Pull through.** Draw the right needle and the wrapped yarn through the stitch, creating a new loop on the right needle.
- 5 **Transfer.** Place this new loop onto the left needle by inserting the left needle into the front of the loop from left to right. Slide the right needle out.
- 6 **Repeat** steps 2–5, each time inserting the right needle into the last stitch you placed on the left needle.

Method 3: Cable Cast On

A variation of the knitted cast on that creates a firm, rope-like edge. Ideal for edges that need structure, like button bands.

- 1 **Start with two stitches** using the knitted cast-on method above.
- 2 **Insert the right needle** between the last two stitches on the left needle (not into a stitch, but between them).
- 3 **Wrap and pull through** as in the knitted cast on.
- 4 **Transfer** the new loop to the left needle.
- 5 **Repeat** steps 2–4, always inserting between the last two stitches.

Method 4: Backward Loop Cast On

The simplest cast on — just loops twisted onto the needle. Best for casting on a few extra stitches mid-row. Not recommended for starting a project because it produces an uneven, loose edge.

- 1 **Make a slip knot** and place it on the needle.
- 2 **Loop the working yarn** around your left thumb from front to back.
- 3 **Insert the needle** into the loop on your thumb from bottom to top.

- 4 Slip your thumb out and gently tighten.
- 5 Repeat until you have the required stitches.

When to Use Each Method

METHOD	EDGE QUALITY	STRETCHINESS	BEST USE
Long-Tail	Neat, even	Moderate	Default for most projects
Knitted	Slightly loose	Moderate	Learning; adding stitches
Cable	Firm, rope-like	Low	Button bands, structural edges
Backward Loop	Loose, uneven	High	Adding a few stitches mid-row

Common Mistake

Making the slip knot too tight. Your slip knot should slide freely along the needle. If it is locked in place, undo it, loosen the knot, and try again.

SECTION 3

The Knit Stitch

Master the most fundamental stitch in knitting — every pattern you will ever make is built on this.

The knit stitch is one of only two stitches in all of knitting. Once you can knit confidently, you already know half of everything you need. Rows of knit stitches create garter stitch — a bumpy, stretchy, reversible fabric.

English Method (Throwing)

In the English method, you hold the working yarn in your right hand and "throw" it around the needle. This is the most common method taught in English-speaking countries.

- 1 **Hold the needle with cast-on stitches in your left hand.** The working yarn (attached to the ball) should hang behind the left needle.
- 2 **Insert the right needle** into the first stitch on the left needle, going from left to right (front to back). The right needle crosses behind the left needle, forming an X.
- 3 **Wrap the yarn.** With your right hand, bring the working yarn counterclockwise around the tip of the right needle (from back, over the top, to front).
- 4 **Pull through.** Carefully slide the right needle tip (with the wrapped yarn) back through the stitch, moving from back to front. You now have a new loop on the right needle.
- 5 **Slide off.** Let the original stitch slip off the left needle. One knit stitch complete.
- 6 **Repeat** across the row. When all stitches have been worked, swap the needles — the full needle goes to your left hand — and begin the next row.

Continental Method (Picking)

In the Continental method, you hold the working yarn in your left hand and "pick" it with the right needle. Many knitters find this faster once learned, and it is essential for colorwork.

- 1 **Hold the yarn in your left hand.** Wrap the working yarn over your left index finger, tensioned through your other fingers. Hold the needle with stitches in your left hand as well.
- 2 **Insert the right needle** into the first stitch from left to right, same as the English method.

- 3 **Catch the yarn.** Use the right needle tip to hook the yarn held on your left index finger, scooping it from left to right.
- 4 **Pull through.** Draw the right needle and caught yarn back through the stitch.
- 5 **Slide off** the old stitch from the left needle.
- 6 **Repeat.** The motion is a small, efficient scoop rather than a throwing motion.

Which Method to Choose?

Neither method is "better." Try both and use whichever feels more natural. You can always learn the other later. Most important: pick one and practice it consistently until it becomes automatic.

Common Mistakes with the Knit Stitch

Inserting the Wrong Way

The right needle must go into the stitch from **left to right** (front to back). Going the other direction twists the stitch and changes the fabric texture.

Wrapping Backward

Always wrap the yarn **counterclockwise** (from back, over the top, to front). Wrapping clockwise creates twisted stitches that are tighter and look different.

Accidental Yarn Overs

If the yarn slips to the front of the work before you insert the needle, the next stitch creates an extra loop (a "yarn over"). Always keep the yarn **behind** the work for knit stitches.

Knitting Too Tightly

If you can barely slide stitches along the needle, you are knitting too tightly. Relax your grip and let the needle do the work. Stitches should move freely.

Practice Exercises

Knit Stitch Practice Plan

- ☐ Cast on 20 stitches using the long-tail method
- ☐ Knit 10 rows. Count your stitches at the end of each row (you should always have 20)
- ☐ Examine your fabric — both sides should look the same (garter stitch)
- ☐ Practice until you can complete a row without looking at your hands constantly
- ☐ Try knitting while watching TV — this tests your muscle memory
- ☐ Knit a 4×4 inch (10×10 cm) swatch. If it takes you fewer than 30 minutes, you are ready to move on

SECTION 4

The Purl Stitch

Learn the second fundamental stitch and unlock stockinette, ribbing, and hundreds of stitch patterns.

The purl stitch is simply the knit stitch worked in reverse. A purl on one side looks like a knit on the other side. Together, knit and purl stitches create every fabric texture in knitting.

How Purl Relates to Knit

Imagine looking at a knit stitch from the back — that is exactly what a purl stitch looks like from the front. When you knit every row, both sides look bumpy (garter stitch). When you **knit one row, purl the next**, you get **stockinette** — smooth Vs on the front, bumps on the back. This is the most common fabric in knitting.

English Method Purl

- 1 **Move the yarn to the front.** The working yarn must be in front of the left needle (between the needles and facing you). This is the key difference from the knit stitch.
- 2 **Insert the right needle** into the first stitch from right to left (back to front). The right needle crosses in front of the left needle.
- 3 **Wrap the yarn.** Bring the working yarn counterclockwise around the right needle tip (from right, over the top, to left).
- 4 **Pull through.** Slide the right needle tip (with the wrap) back through the stitch, moving from front to back.
- 5 **Slide off** the old stitch from the left needle. One purl stitch complete.

Continental Method Purl

- 1 **Bring the yarn to the front** and hold it tensioned over your left index finger, slightly lower than for knitting.
- 2 **Insert the right needle** from right to left into the first stitch.
- 3 **Scoop the yarn.** Dip the right needle tip down and to the left to catch the yarn from your index finger.

- 4

Pull through the stitch from front to back.
- 5

Slide off the old stitch.

The #1 Purl Mistake

Forgetting to move the yarn to the front before purling. If the yarn is in back, you will accidentally create a yarn over (extra stitch) when you bring it forward. Always check: yarn in front before you insert the needle.

Key Fabric Patterns with Knit & Purl

PATTERN	HOW TO WORK IT	LOOKS LIKE	PROPERTIES
Garter Stitch	Knit every row	Horizontal ridges on both sides	Lies flat, stretchy, reversible
Stockinette	Knit 1 row, purl 1 row	Smooth Vs on front, bumps on back	Curls at edges, most common fabric
1×1 Ribbing	*Knit 1, purl 1* across	Vertical columns	Very stretchy, great for cuffs and hems
2×2 Ribbing	*Knit 2, purl 2* across	Wider vertical columns	Stretchy, classic sweater edge
Seed Stitch	*K1, P1* row 1; *P1, K1* row 2	Scattered bumps	Lies flat, textured, reversible

Practice Exercises

Purl Stitch Practice Plan

- ☐ Cast on 20 stitches and purl every row for 10 rows (this also makes garter stitch)
- ☐ Cast on 20 stitches and alternate: Row 1 knit, Row 2 purl. Do 20 rows for stockinette
- ☐ Cast on 20 stitches and work *K1, P1* across every row for 10 rows (1×1 ribbing)
- ☐ Compare your three swatches — notice how the same two stitches create totally different fabrics

Yarn Position Rule

There is one simple rule that prevents most beginner mistakes: **yarn in back for knit, yarn in front for purl**. Every time you switch between knit and purl within a row (like in ribbing), move the yarn between the needles — never over them.

SECTION 5

Binding Off

Secure your stitches so your work does not unravel — the final step for every project.

Binding off (also called "casting off") locks your live stitches into a finished edge. The method you choose affects how stretchy or firm that edge is.

Standard Bind Off

The most common and simplest method. Creates a clean, slightly firm edge.

- 1 **Knit the first two stitches** onto the right needle as normal.
- 2 **Lift the first stitch over.** Insert the left needle into the first stitch you knitted (the one farther from the tip) and lift it over the second stitch and off the right needle. One stitch bound off.
- 3 **Knit one more stitch** so you again have two stitches on the right needle.
- 4 **Lift over again.** Repeat: lift the first stitch over the second and off.
- 5 **Continue** until one stitch remains on the right needle.
- 6 **Cut the yarn** leaving a 6-inch (15 cm) tail. Pull the tail through the last loop and tighten gently.

Too-Tight Bind Off

This is the most common bind-off problem. If your bound-off edge is tighter than the rest of the fabric and puckers, try using a needle one or two sizes larger in your right hand when binding off.

Stretchy Bind Off (Jeny's Stretchy Bind Off)

Creates an elastic edge that matches the stretch of ribbing. Essential for hat brims, sock cuffs, and necklines.

- 1 **Before each knit stitch:** make a reverse yarn over (bring yarn from back to front over the needle).
- 2 **Knit the next stitch.** You now have two loops on the right needle (the yarn over and the knit stitch).
- 3 **Lift the yarn over** over the knit stitch and off the needle.
- 4 **Before each purl stitch:** make a regular yarn over (bring yarn from front to back over the needle).

- 5 **Purl the next stitch**, then lift the yarn over and the previous stitch over, one at a time.
- 6 **Continue** matching yarn overs to the stitch type (reverse YO before knits, regular YO before purls) until one stitch remains. Cut and pull through.

Three-Needle Bind Off

Joins two pieces together while binding off at the same time. Used for shoulder seams and other joins where you want a clean, flat seam.

- 1 **Place both pieces on separate needles** with the same number of stitches, right sides facing together (wrong sides facing out).
- 2 **Hold both needles in your left hand**, tips pointing the same direction. Use a third needle in your right hand.
- 3 **Insert the right needle** knitwise through the first stitch on the front needle and the first stitch on the back needle at the same time.
- 4 **Knit them together** as one stitch.
- 5 **Repeat** with the next pair of stitches. You now have two stitches on the right needle.
- 6 **Lift the first stitch over the second** and off, just like a standard bind off.
- 7 **Continue** until one stitch remains. Cut and pull through.

Which Bind Off to Use

Standard bind off works for most situations. Use the stretchy bind off for edges that need to stretch (hat brims, necklines, ribbed edges). Use the three-needle bind off when joining two knitted pieces at a seam.

SECTION 6

Reading Patterns

Decode any knitting pattern — from abbreviations to charts to sizing — so you can follow any design with confidence.

A knitting pattern is a set of instructions written in a condensed shorthand. It looks intimidating at first, but once you learn the abbreviations and structure, it reads like a recipe — materials, measurements, and step-by-step directions.

Standard Abbreviations

ABBREVIATION	MEANING	ABBREVIATION	MEANING
K	Knit	P	Purl
CO	Cast on	BO	Bind off
St(s)	Stitch(es)	Rep	Repeat
RS	Right side (front)	WS	Wrong side (back)
K2tog	Knit 2 together (decrease)	SSK	Slip, slip, knit (decrease)
YO	Yarn over (increase)	M1	Make 1 (increase)
Sl	Slip (move without knitting)	PM	Place marker
Kfb	Knit front and back (increase)	Tog	Together
DPN	Double-pointed needle	Rnd	Round (circular knitting)

Anatomy of a Pattern

Most patterns follow this structure:

- 1 Header:** Name, designer, skill level, finished measurements.
- 2 Materials:** Yarn (weight, yardage, recommended brand), needles (size and type), notions (stitch markers, tapestry needle, etc.).
- 3 Gauge:** How many stitches and rows per inch or 4 inches (10 cm). This is critical — if your gauge does not match, your finished piece will be the wrong size.

- 4 **Sizing:** Multiple sizes listed as S (M, L, XL). Your size's numbers appear in the same position throughout. Highlight or circle your size before starting.
- 5 **Instructions:** Row-by-row or section-by-section directions using abbreviations.
- 6 **Finishing:** Seaming, blocking, and weaving in ends.

Understanding Repeats

Patterns use special notation to save space:

Asterisks (*)

K2, P2 means repeat "K2, P2" across the row. Sometimes written as: *K2, P2; rep from * to end.

Brackets []

[K1, P1] 3 times means work the bracketed sequence 3 times in a row: K1, P1, K1, P1, K1, P1.

Parentheses for Sizes

CO 60 (68, 76, 84) sts means: cast on 60 for S, 68 for M, 76 for L, 84 for XL.

Row Repeats

Rep Rows 1–4 until piece measures 10" means keep cycling through those 4 rows until you reach the length.

Reading a Knitting Chart

Charts are a visual grid where each square represents one stitch. They are read differently from text:

- **RS rows** (odd-numbered) are read **right to left**.
- **WS rows** (even-numbered) are read **left to right**.
- Each symbol represents a specific stitch (the chart will include a key).
- Row numbers appear on the side where you begin reading that row.
- A blank or empty square typically means "knit on RS, purl on WS."
- A dot typically means "purl on RS, knit on WS."
- Highlighted or boxed sections indicate the repeat.

Sample Annotated Pattern

Simple Dishcloth

Beginner

MATERIALS

Worsted weight cotton yarn, 50 g / 85 yds. US 8 (5 mm) needles.

GAUGE

18 sts × 24 rows = 4" (10 cm) in garter stitch. ← *This tells you how many stitches per inch you should get.*

INSTRUCTIONS

CO 4 sts. ← *Cast on 4 stitches to start.*

Row 1: K across. ← *Knit all 4 stitches.*

Row 2: K2, YO, K to end. ← *Knit 2, yarn over (adds 1 stitch), knit remaining stitches. You now have 5 sts.*

Rep Row 2 until you have 40 sts. ← *Keep repeating. Each row adds 1 stitch via the yarn over.*

Dec Row: K1, K2tog, YO, K2tog, K to end. ← *Now you decrease 1 stitch per row.*

Rep Dec Row until 4 sts remain.

BO all sts. Weave in ends.

Pattern-Reading Tip

Before you start knitting, read the entire pattern once without doing anything. Mark your size, highlight any unfamiliar abbreviations, and check that you have all the materials listed. This five-minute investment saves hours of frustration.

SECTION 7

Your First Scarf

Knit a complete, wearable scarf using only the skills you have learned so far.

This scarf uses garter stitch — knit every row. No purling, no shaping, no complicated techniques. It is the perfect project to build confidence and create something you can actually wear.

Pattern: Classic Garter Stitch Scarf

Beginner

Flat Knitting

Garter Stitch

FINISHED MEASUREMENTS

Approximately 6 inches (15 cm) wide × 60 inches (152 cm) long.

MATERIALS

You Will Need

- ☐ 2 skeins worsted weight yarn (#4), approximately 200 yards (180 m) each — total ~400 yards
- ☐ US 8 (5 mm) straight needles, 10 inches (25 cm) or longer
- ☐ Tapestry needle for weaving in ends
- ☐ Scissors

GAUGE

18 stitches × 36 rows = 4 inches (10 cm) in garter stitch. Exact gauge is not critical for a scarf, but knit a small swatch first to make sure your fabric feels right — not too stiff, not too floppy.

INSTRUCTIONS

- 1** Cast on **28 stitches** using the long-tail cast on.
- 2** **Row 1:** Knit every stitch across the row. Turn your work.
- 3** **Repeat Row 1** for every row. That is the entire pattern — knit every stitch, every row.

- 4 **Count your stitches** at the end of every row for the first 10 rows to make sure you are not accidentally adding or losing stitches. You should always have 28.
- 5 **When you reach the end of your first skein**, join the second skein: leave a 6-inch tail from the old yarn, start knitting with the new yarn (also leaving a 6-inch tail), and continue. You will weave in these tails later.
- 6 **Continue knitting** until your scarf measures 60 inches (152 cm) or your desired length, and you have enough yarn left for binding off (at least 3 times the width of the scarf).
- 7 **Bind off all stitches** using the standard bind off. Keep the tension relaxed so the bound-off edge matches the cast-on edge.
- 8 **Weave in ends**. Thread each yarn tail onto the tapestry needle and weave it through the bumps on the back of the fabric for about 2 inches (5 cm), then reverse direction for 1 inch. Trim the excess.
- 9 **Block your scarf (optional)**. Soak it in lukewarm water for 20 minutes, gently squeeze out excess water with a towel (do not wring), lay flat on a towel, shape to dimensions, and let dry completely. This evens out your stitches and gives a polished finish.

Slipped-Stitch Selvedge (Optional)

For neater edges, slip the first stitch of every row purlwise (move it from the left to the right needle without knitting it), then knit the rest. This creates a clean chain along each edge.

Stitch Count Changing?

If you end a row with more or fewer than 28 stitches, you are accidentally adding or dropping stitches. The most common cause: bringing the yarn over the needle at the start of a row instead of keeping it behind. Count every row until this stops happening.

SECTION 8

Your First Hat

Step up from flat knitting to shaping — knit a complete, fitted hat from brim to crown.

This hat introduces two new skills: ribbing (knit and purl in the same row) and decreases (reducing stitches to shape the crown). It is knitted flat on straight needles and seamed, so you do not need circular needles yet.

Pattern: Classic Ribbed Beanie

Beginner+

Flat Knitting

Seamed

FINISHED MEASUREMENTS

Fits average adult head, 20–22 inches (51–56 cm) circumference. Hat measures approximately 9.5 inches (24 cm) wide laid flat × 9 inches (23 cm) tall.

MATERIALS

You Will Need

- ☐ 1 skein worsted weight yarn (#4), approximately 200 yards (180 m)
- ☐ US 8 (5 mm) straight needles
- ☐ Tapestry needle for seaming and weaving in ends
- ☐ Scissors
- ☐ 4 stitch markers (optional, but helpful for crown decreases)

GAUGE

18 stitches × 24 rows = 4 inches (10 cm) in stockinette stitch. Gauge matters for a hat — knit a swatch and measure it. If you have too many stitches per inch, switch to larger needles. Too few, use smaller needles.

INSTRUCTIONS

Brim

- 1** Cast on **84 stitches** using the long-tail cast on.
- 2** **Row 1 (RS):** *K2, P2; repeat from * to end.

- 3 **Row 2 (WS):** *K2, P2; repeat from * to end. (Because this is 2×2 ribbing, both sides work the same: knit the knits and purl the purls.)
- 4 **Repeat Rows 1–2** for a total of 14 rows (about 2 inches / 5 cm). This creates the stretchy ribbed brim.

Body

- 5 **Row 15 (RS):** Knit all stitches across.
- 6 **Row 16 (WS):** Purl all stitches across.
- 7 **Repeat Rows 15–16** (stockinette stitch) until the piece measures 7 inches (18 cm) from the cast-on edge, ending on a WS (purl) row.

Crown Decreases

- 8 **Decrease Row 1 (RS):** *K5, K2tog; repeat from * to end. *(72 sts remain.)*
- 9 **Row 9 (WS) and all WS rows:** Purl across.
- 10 **Decrease Row 2 (RS):** *K4, K2tog; repeat from * to end. *(60 sts.)*
- 11 **Decrease Row 3 (RS):** *K3, K2tog; repeat from * to end. *(48 sts.)*
- 12 **Decrease Row 4 (RS):** *K2, K2tog; repeat from * to end. *(36 sts.)*
- 13 **Decrease Row 5 (RS):** *K1, K2tog; repeat from * to end. *(24 sts.)*
- 14 **Decrease Row 6 (RS):** *K2tog; repeat from * to end. *(12 sts.)*

Finishing

- 15 **Cut the yarn** leaving a 24-inch (60 cm) tail. Thread the tail through the tapestry needle.
- 16 **Thread through remaining stitches.** Pass the tapestry needle through each of the 12 stitches on the knitting needle, slipping them off as you go. Pull tight to close the top of the hat.
- 17 **Seam the hat.** With the same tail, use mattress stitch or whip stitch to sew the side edges together from the crown down to the brim. For mattress stitch: pick up one bar between the first and second stitch on one side, then the corresponding bar on the other side, alternating down the seam. Pull gently every few stitches to close the seam.
- 18 **Weave in all ends** and turn the hat right side out.

Block (optional). Soak briefly, squeeze out water in a towel, and dry over a bowl or balloon that matches your head size.

Understanding the Decreases

K2tog (knit two together) is simple: insert your needle into two stitches instead of one and knit them as a single stitch. Each K2tog reduces your stitch count by one. By spacing them evenly, the crown narrows smoothly into a circle.

Before You Start

Check your gauge. A hat that is even half an inch too big will slide over your eyes. Knit a 4×4 inch swatch in stockinette, wash and dry it the way you will wash the hat, and measure. Adjust needle size if needed.

SECTION 9

Troubleshooting for Beginners

Diagnose and fix the most common problems every new knitter encounters.

Every knitter has made these mistakes — they are a normal part of learning. Knowing how to identify and fix them means a small error never becomes a ruined project.

Dropped Stitches

Problem

You notice a loop hanging below your needle, or a ladder of loose yarn running down your work. A stitch has slipped off the needle and is unraveling.

Solution

Do not panic — a dropped stitch can always be fixed. (1) Insert a crochet hook or the tip of your needle into the dropped loop from front to back. (2) Catch the horizontal bar of yarn (the "ladder rung") directly above the loop. (3) Pull the bar through the loop. This recreates one row. (4) Repeat for each ladder rung until you reach the current row. (5) Place the recovered stitch back on the left needle, making sure it is not twisted (the right leg should be in front of the needle). If you do not have a crochet hook, a bobby pin works in a pinch.

Uneven Tension

Problem

Some stitches are tight while others are loose, giving your fabric a lumpy or inconsistent look. The edges may be much tighter or looser than the middle.

Solution

Tension improves naturally with practice — this is the most common beginner issue and it will get better. To speed up improvement: (1) Focus on keeping the yarn wrapped around your fingers consistently. (2) After completing each stitch, gently tug the working yarn to snug it — not tight, just even. (3) Try to knit at a steady pace without stopping mid-row. (4) Knit a swatch every week and compare them — you will see dramatic improvement. Blocking (wetting and reshaping) also evens out minor tension differences in the finished piece.

Fabric Too Tight or Too Loose

Problem — Too Tight

Your stitches are hard to slide along the needle. Your fabric feels stiff and dense. Your stitch count per inch is higher than the pattern's gauge.

Solution

Switch to needles one or two sizes larger. Consciously relax your grip — you should be guiding the yarn, not strangling it. Some knitters find that switching to a different needle material helps (metal needles are slippery and reduce the effect of a tight grip).

Problem — Too Loose

Your fabric is floppy and see-through. Stitches slide around too easily. Your stitch count per inch is lower than the gauge.

Solution

Switch to needles one or two sizes smaller. Add a bit more tension by wrapping the yarn around one more finger. Bamboo or wood needles add slight friction that helps with loose knitting.

Accidental Increases (Extra Stitches)

Problem

Your stitch count keeps growing. Your fabric is getting wider. You started with 28 stitches and now have 31.

Solution

The most common causes: (1) **Yarn overs at the start of a row** — make sure the yarn is behind the needle before you knit the first stitch. If the yarn is draped over the needle, it creates an extra loop. (2) **Knitting into the bar between stitches** — make sure you are inserting your needle into actual stitches, not the horizontal strands between them. (3) **Splitting the yarn** — if your needle goes through the middle of a yarn strand, it can create two loops from one stitch. Count your stitches at the end of every row until this stops happening.

Accidental Decreases (Missing Stitches)

Problem

Your stitch count is shrinking. Your fabric is getting narrower. You cannot figure out where stitches are going.

Solution

(1) **Dropping stitches** — check for ladders in your work and pick them up (see above). (2) **Knitting two together** — you may be accidentally inserting your needle into two stitches instead of one, especially at the edges. Slow down and make sure each stitch is separate before you knit it. (3) **Losing the last stitch** — the last stitch of a row can slip off unnoticed. After finishing each row, check that the first and last stitches are secure on the needle.

Twisted Cast On

Problem

Your cast-on row looks twisted or spiraled, especially noticeable when working in the round (circular knitting).

Solution

Before you join for knitting in the round (or before you knit the second row flat), check that all your cast-on stitches are facing the same direction — the bottom edge of each stitch should line up along the bottom of the needle. If any stitches are twisted around the needle, straighten them before proceeding. Once you knit past a twisted cast on, you cannot fix it without starting over.

Miscounting Rows

Problem

You lost track of what row you are on, and the pattern requires specific actions on specific rows.

Solution

(1) Use a **row counter** — click it at the end of every row. (2) For garter stitch, count the **ridges** on one side — each ridge equals 2 rows. (3) For stockinette, count the **V shapes** stacked vertically — each V is one row. (4) Keep a notepad or use a knitting app to track your position in the pattern. (5) Place a **locking stitch marker** on your fabric every 10 or 20 rows as a checkpoint.

Quick Reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	QUICK FIX
Stitch count increasing	Yarn over at row start; split yarn	Keep yarn behind needle; count every row
Stitch count decreasing	Dropped stitch; knitting 2 together	Pick up dropped stitch; slow down at edges
Holes in fabric	Accidental yarn overs	Check yarn position before each stitch
Curling edges	Stockinette naturally curls	Normal — blocking or a border fixes it
Tight first row	Tight cast on	Cast onto two needles held together
Uneven edges	Inconsistent first/last stitch	Slip first stitch of every row purlwise
Twisted stitches	Wrapping yarn the wrong direction	Always wrap counterclockwise

Next Step

You now have every skill you need to start knitting real projects. Open **The Great Stitch Library** and pick a stitch pattern that catches your eye — try it on a small swatch first, then incorporate it into your next scarf or hat. Every pattern in The Ultimate Knitting Library builds on the techniques you just learned.